

MBEYA UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY
COLLEGE OF HUMANITIES AND BUSINESS STUDIES
DEPARTMENT OF HUMANITIES
UQF8 FIRST YEAR
ACADEMIC YEAR: 2022/2023 (SEMESTER ONE)
HS 8101: COMMUNICATION SKILLS

COURSE INSTRUCTOR: MR. Nsyengula Partson Stephen

[OFFICE: Electrical Wing, Basement Room #018-A]



1. INTRODUCTION TO COMMUNICATION SKILLS

The Concept of Communication

- Communication is every day and every one activity
- People earn money, connect to fellows, and their God through communication
- The term communication according to Timm (1986) is traced from the Latin word “communicare” which means ‘to make common’.
- The idea is that when I share my idea with somebody else, means that idea becomes common therefore, we have communicated
- Is the art and process of creating and sharing ideas (MTD, 2012)
- It occurs intentionally or unintentionally; consciously or unconsciously.



..Cont.

- For example; smiling, speaking to someone, shaking hands, a picture on the wall, a smell of a nice perfume, a dog barking, a tree shading leaves, a loud music, dressing style/code etc.
- All these communicate a certain message, thus, communication is not limited to human beings.
- Other entities such as animals, objects, plants etc. also communicate various messages
- People communicate with each other at home, at work place, in classroom, in vehicles , in public gathering etc.
- Communication forms an integral part of everyday human activities
- Advancement of service and technology has made communication even easier through television, radio, mobile phones, magazines, internet etc.



Defining Features of Communication

The process of communication depends on the elements of communication which make it complete. The elements of communication are;

- i. Presence of sender: source of communication, encodes the message
- ii. Receiver: destination of the message, decodes the message. Receiver can be intended or unintended.
- iii. Message: information you intend to communicate. Have various meanings depending on context.
- iv. Channel: medium you use to convey the message; speaking, writing, body movement etc. It is like a vehicle that carries the message to receiver.



..Cont.

v. Setting/context: A combination of circumstances that influence a piece of communication at a certain point of time.

Situation in which you communicate. Physical environment, time of a day, relationship b/n interlocutors , culture etc.

vi. Feedback: The immediate response of the receiver to the message. Helps to gauge success of the communication.

vii. Noise: any thing that interferes/disrupts the communication process, physical or psychological.

viii. Effect: desired change after communication. The messages we send and receive are powerful enough to cause action, change the state of being and influence particular behavior. For example: when someone decides to commit suicide after receiving the message.



Types of Communication

Criteria:

1) Number of individuals

a) Intrapersonal communication: within one self

b) Interpersonal communication: among at least two people

✓ Small group communication. Just few individuals are involved

✓ Large group communication. Big number of people are involved

❖ **Public communication:** Occurs when one individual address the audiences.

Here both the speaker and the audiences should be present in the setting where communication takes place for example, public speeches and public lectures



..Cont.

❖ **Mass communication:** Occurs when an individual delivers the message to the mass. In mass communication it is not necessary for a speaker to be together with the audience in the same setting. For example, news presentation in a radio or TV programmes, films, movies and numerous theatric performances on TV.

2) *Channel*

a) Verbal communication

- ✓ Involves exchange of information using spoken words
- ✓ Commonly referred to as oral communication
- ✓ Occurs in meetings, talks, discussions, presentations, interviews, speeches etc.



..Cont.

b) Nonverbal communication

- ✓ This is wordless form of communication
- ✓ It takes the form of postures, gestures, facial expression etc.
- ✓ Cues and signs are the main tools used in this type

C) Written communication

- ✓ Here you communicate through writings
- ✓ Possible with literate people only (writing&reading)
- ✓ Commonly used in formal settings
- ✓ Letters, reports, research papers, articles, note taking etc.



..cont.

3) *Power Relation*

a) Vertical communication: people with differences in power and status

-*Top-down communication*

- *Down-top communication*

b) Horizontal communication: people with equivalent power and status



Effective Communication

What is Effective Communication?

- The meaning of effective communication can be delivered from the two words “effective” and “communication” to mean that a message successfully reaches to the targeted destination and comprehended as intended by the sender.
- In other words, effective communication is the communication that put away all barriers of communication.
- Communication which is transmitted smoothly in uninterrupted flow, in such a way that only the intended message reaches the target receiver at a required time and in the planned setting with the desired effect



..Cont.

o **Characteristics of effective communication:**

- *Clarity*: be clear. Choose simple/familiar words and use short sentences to express your ideas.
- *Correctness*: correct use of grammar to present a correct message
- *Completeness*: the message must be complete, providing all the necessary information
- *Consideration*: consider the receiver ability and level of understanding
- *Conciseness*: be brief
- *Concreteness*: be brief, avoid all redundant words/expressions
- *Courtesy*: *Courtesy*: speaker/writer being aware of the listener's/reader's feelings, that is to say communicate wisely.



Importance of Communication

- Communication creates understanding among people involved in certain physical activity whose successful accomplishment requires joint effort.
- Communication reduces unnecessary stress and frustrations among individuals. People relieve their anger when they speak out.
- Communication creates friendly relations among people in the society.
- Communication enables individuals express their ideas, feelings, emotions, attitudes and point of view to others and understand others' point of view.



..cont.

- Communication enhances sharing of information among individuals within their societies.
- Communication increases performance at workplaces.
- Communication enables an individual to make self criticism, and hence change certain undesirable behaviour and false beliefs.
- Communication enables an individual to solve particular problem.
- Communication is an entertainment, makes us cheerful.



The Negative Side of Communication

- Communication may lead into unnecessary conflicts among people.
- Communication may be time consuming.
- It is costly in terms of money, resources and profession.
- Communication may lead to unnecessary accidents, which in turn may cause injuries, deaths, damage and loss of properties.
- Communication may sometimes be a disturbance.



Barriers to Effective Communication

What is a barrier of communication?

- A barrier of communication is also called **noise** of communication
- It is interference, interruption or an obstruction that negatively affects the message from being understood as intended or expected.
- It is anything that interferes with communication leading to the failure or breakdown of communication.
 - May hinder smooth **transmission** of the message, **alter** the message, may lead to the **loss of part** of the message, or completely **loss of the entire** message.
 - Can originate from the sender, receiver, message, channel or the setting.
- Therefore, it is important to be aware of common barriers.



..cont.

i. **The use of jargon and slangs**

Jargons are technical words and phrases used to communicate by people in a specific profession. These words which may not be understood by average people who do not belong to that particular profession. Jargons differ from one profession to another. For example technical words used by engineers, doctors, lawyers etc. Some jargons like adjournment, defendant, diagnosis, coding, pedagogy etc. These might be a cause for communication barrier.

Similarly, the use of slang also makes communication ineffective. Slang is informal words and expressions used by a particular group of people. For example the use of a slang “grass” to describe marijuana can act as a barrier for the people who do not know the meaning of a particular slang.

..cont.

ii. Overloaded with information

This yet is another common cause of communication breakdown. When too much information is communicated at the same time, there are chances that the recipient may not understand this information and becomes confused. If you don't control the flow of information, the message is likely to be misinterpreted, forgotten or overlooked.

iii. Psychological barrier

This is related to the people's state of mind. It happens when there is misperception, too much worries, stress, filtering of information, distrust, wandering mind, anger, hatred, disappointment, lack of interest to the speaker or and the topic etc.



..cont.

iv. Physical barrier

There are many things in the environment that may pose difficulties in communication. For example a wall between the interlocutors, loud music, passing vehicles, poor hand writing, unclear photocopies, poor lighting, uncomfortable sitting, unhygienic room, even bad weather condition, when it is too hot or too cold people become uncomfortable.

v. Social - cultural barriers

Often times, social - cultural diversity also results in communication breakdown because some information shared may be interpreted differently in different societies/cultures. For example some signals are not universal across cultures so, when used can have offensive message. Economic status, gender, religion and taboos are also related to cultures.

..cont.

vi. Personality

Personality here means various combined individual person characters that make him different from the other. It is hard to listen from a speaker who appears different from what we consider as normal. Unusual clothing, radical hair style, mannerism, heavy jewels etc. may distract the flow of the intended message.

vii. Other barriers

Information distortion, use of informal abbreviations & short forms, inadequate information, poor listening skills, poor retention, individual linguistic ability, technological failure, inappropriate channel, complex hierarchy/protocols etc.

